What He Promises You

הֲרֵי אַתְּ מְקֻדֶּשֶׁת לִי

The ketubah, line by line, and what the Rambam adds to it

> **Close your eyes.** *It is your wedding. You are standing under the chuppah. The man you have chosen turns to you, in front of two witnesses and everyone you love, and in front of Hashem, and he says this to you.*

The Ketubah הַכְּתֻבָּה

The part of the document in which he binds himself to you, day to day: what he will give, and what he will be. In the original, then in English.

1

הֲוִי לִי לְאִנְתּוּ כְּדַת מֹשֶׁה וְיִשְׂרָאֵל

Be my wife, according to the law of Moshe and Israel.

2

וַאֲנָא אֶפְלַח וְאוֹקִיר וְאֵיזוֹן וַאֲפַרְנֵס יָתִיכִי

And I will work for you, I will honor you, I will feed you, and I will support you,

3

כְּהִלְכוֹת גְּבִרִין יְהוּדָאִין דְּפָלְחִין וּמוֹקְרִין וְזָנִין וּמְפַרְנְסִין לְנָשֵׁיהוֹן בְּקוּשְׁטָא

as Jewish men do, who work for, honor, feed and support their wives, in truth.

4

וְיָהֵיבְנָא לִיכִי מֹהַר בְּתוּלַיְכִי כְּסַף זוּזֵי מָאתָן דְּחָזֵי לִיכִי מִדְּאוֹרַיְתָא

And I give you the mohar of your maidenhood, two hundred silver zuz, which is yours by the Torah,

5

וּמְזוֹנַיְכִי וּכְסוּתַיְכִי וְסִפּוּקַיְכִי

and your food, and your clothing, and everything you need,

6

וּמִיעַל לְוָתַיְכִי כְּאוֹרַח כָּל אַרְעָא

and I will be with you in physical intimacy, as a husband is with his wife, the way of all the world.

The intimate life of the marriage is written into the document as his obligation to her: to want her, to come to her, to give her that closeness. It is not listed as something she owes him.

7

וּצְבִיאַת מָרַת פְּלוֹנִית בְּתוּלְתָּא דָּא וַהֲוַת לֵיהּ לְאִנְתּוּ

And she agreed, and became his wife.

Your one line in the whole document. Everything before it is what he gives. This is your yes.

8

וְהַכֹּל שָׁרִיר וְקַיָּם

And all of it is firm and binding.

What the Rambam adds הִלְכוֹת אִישׁוּת

The ketubah is the summary. The Rambam, in Hilchot Ishut, spells out what each promise actually means. Even if none of it was written, he says, she has all of it the moment she is married.

Ten things he owes you הל' אישות יב:א–ב

כְּשֶׁנּוֹשֵׂא אָדָם אִשָּׁה... יִתְחַיֵּב לָהּ בַּעֲשָׂרָה דְּבָרִים... שְׁלֹשָׁה מֵהֶן מִן הַתּוֹרָה: "שְׁאֵרָהּ, כְּסוּתָהּ וְעוֹנָתָהּ". שְׁאֵרָהּ אֵלּוּ מְזוֹנוֹתֶיהָ, כְּסוּתָהּ כְּמַשְׁמָעוֹ, עוֹנָתָהּ לָבֹא עָלֶיהָ כְּדֶרֶךְ כָּל הָאָרֶץ. וְהַשִּׁבְעָה מִדִּבְרֵי סוֹפְרִים... לְרַפֹּאתָהּ אִם חָלְתָה, וְלִפְדוֹתָהּ אִם נִשְׁבֵּית, לְקָבְרָהּ אִם מֵתָה, וְלִהְיוֹת נְזוֹנֶת מִן נְכָסָיו וְיוֹשֶׁבֶת בְּבֵיתוֹ אַחַר מוֹתוֹ כָּל זְמַן אַלְמְנוּתָהּ...

When a man marries a woman, he becomes obligated to her in ten things. Three are from the Torah: her food, her clothing, and her intimacy. Seven are from the Sages, and every one of them is a condition of the ketubah even if it was never written:

1. Her food
2. Her clothing
3. Physical intimacy, as husband and wife
4. The ketubah money itself
5. To heal her if she is sick
6. To redeem her if she is captured
7. To bury her, with honor, if she dies
8. To support her from his property, in his house, as long as she is a widow
9. To support her daughters from his property until they are betrothed
10. Her sons inherit her ketubah, beyond their share

"All these things, even though they were not written in the ketubah, and even if no ketubah was written at all: once he married her, she has her ten." (יב:ה)

Food: not survival, a table יב:י–יא

פּוֹסְקִין לָהּ לֶחֶם שְׁתֵּי סְעֻדּוֹת בְּכָל יוֹם... וּפוֹסְקִין לָהּ פַּרְפֶּרֶת לֶאֱכֹל בָּהּ אֶת הַפַּת... וְשֶׁמֶן לַאֲכִילָה וְשֶׁמֶן לְהַדְלָקַת הַנֵּר וּפֵרוֹת וּמְעַט יַיִן... וּפוֹסְקִין לָהּ שָׁלֹשׁ סְעֻדּוֹת בְּשַׁבָּת וּבָשָׂר אוֹ דָּגִים כְּמִנְהַג הַמָּקוֹם. וְנוֹתֵן לָהּ בְּכָל שַׁבָּת וְשַׁבָּת מָעָה כֶּסֶף לִצְרָכֶיהָ... אֲבָל אִם הָיָה עָשִׁיר הַכֹּל לְפִי עָשְׁרוֹ.

Two proper meals a day, bread with something to eat it with, oil for food and oil for the lamp, fruit, a little wine where women drink wine. Three meals on Shabbat with meat or fish. And every single week, money of her own for her own needs. All that is the minimum, for the poorest man in Israel. If he is wealthy, everything rises with his wealth.

Clothing, every season יג:א

נוֹתְנִין לָהּ חֲדָשִׁים בִּימוֹת הַגְּשָׁמִים וְלוֹבֶשֶׁת בְּלָאוֹתֶיהֶן בִּימוֹת הַחַמָּה... וְנוֹתְנִין לָהּ חֲגוֹרָה לְמָתְנֶיהָ וְכִפָּה לְרֹאשָׁהּ וּמִנְעָל מִמּוֹעֵד לְמוֹעֵד.

New clothes every winter. A belt, a head covering, and new shoes every Yom Tov. The worn clothes stay hers.

A home of her own, and what is in it יג:ג

וּבְכָלַל הַכְּסוּת שֶׁהוּא חַיָּב לִתֵּן לָהּ כְּלֵי בַּיִת וּמָדוֹר שֶׁיּוֹשֶׁבֶת בּוֹ... מִטָּה מֻצַּעַת... וּכְלֵי אֲכִילָה וּשְׁתִיָּה... וְהַמָּדוֹר שֶׁשּׁוֹכֵר לָהּ בַּיִת... וְתִהְיֶה רְחָבָה חוּצָה לוֹ כְּדֵי לְהִשְׁתַּמֵּשׁ בָּהּ.

A made bed, a place to sit, pots and plates and cups. A home that is hers to live in, with a yard outside it to use. He cannot keep her in his parents' house.

Beauty: jewelry, color, and makeup יג:ד–ה

וְכֵן מְחַיְּבִין אוֹתוֹ לִתֵּן לָהּ תַּכְשִׁיטִים, כְּגוֹן בִּגְדֵי צִבְעוֹנִין לְהַקִּיף עַל רֹאשָׁהּ וּפַדַּחְתָּהּ, וּפוּךְ וְשָׂרָק וְכַיּוֹצֵא בָּהּ, כְּדֵי שֶׁלֹּא תִּתְגַּנֶּה עָלָיו... וַאֲפִלּוּ הָיָה רָאוּי לְקָנוֹת לָהּ כְּלֵי מֶשִׁי וְרִקְמָה וּכְלֵי זָהָב, כּוֹפִין אוֹתוֹ וְנוֹתֵן.

The court obligates him to give her adornments: colored cloths for her head and brow, eye-paint and rouge, so that she is always beautiful in his eyes. And if he can afford silk, embroidery and gold, he is compelled to give them. Her beauty is not a luxury he grants. It is a need he owes.

Closeness, and never withholding it יד:א, יד:ז

עוֹנָה הָאֲמוּרָה בַּתּוֹרָה, לְכָל אִישׁ וְאִישׁ כְּפִי כֹּחוֹ וּכְפִי מְלַאכְתּוֹ... אָסוּר לָאָדָם לִמְנֹעַ אִשְׁתּוֹ מֵעוֹנָתָהּ, וְאִם עָבַר וּמָנַע כְּדֵי לְצַעֲרָהּ, עָבַר בְּלֹא תַּעֲשֶׂה שֶׁבַּתּוֹרָה.

Intimacy is his duty to her, measured by his strength and his work. A man may not withhold it from his wife, and if he withholds it to hurt her, he has broken a Torah prohibition. Not her duty to him. His to her.

If she is sick ידּ:יז

הָאִשָּׁה שֶׁחָלְתָה, חַיָּב לְרַפְּאוֹת אוֹתָהּ עַד שֶׁתַּבְרִיא.

If she falls ill, he is obligated to heal her until she is well.

If she is taken ידּ:יח–יט

נִשְׁבֵּית, חַיָּב לִפְדּוֹתָהּ... וְאָמַר הֲרֵינִי מְגָרְשָׁהּ וְזוֹ כְּתֻבָּתָהּ וְתֵלֵךְ וְתִפְדֶּה אֶת עַצְמָהּ, אֵין שׁוֹמְעִין לוֹ, אֶלָּא כּוֹפִין אוֹתוֹ וּפוֹדֶה אוֹתָהּ, אֲפִלּוּ הָיוּ דָּמֶיהָ עַד עֲשָׂרָה בִּכְתֻבָּתָהּ, וַאֲפִלּוּ אֵין לוֹ אֶלָּא כְּדֵי פִּדְיוֹנָהּ.

If she is captured, he must redeem her. If he says, "Here is her ketubah money, let her redeem herself," the court does not listen to him. They compel him to redeem her himself, even if her ransom is ten times her ketubah, and even if it is everything he has.

Even after ידּ:כג

מֵתָה אִשְׁתּוֹ, חַיָּב בִּקְבוּרָתָהּ וְלַעֲשׂוֹת לָהּ מִסְפֵּד וְקִינִים כְּדֶרֶךְ כָּל הַמְּדִינָה... וְאִם הָיָה כְּבוֹדָהּ יוֹתֵר מִכְּבוֹדוֹ, קוֹבְרִין אוֹתָהּ לְפִי כְּבוֹדָהּ, שֶׁהָאִשָּׁה עוֹלָה עִם בַּעְלָהּ וְאֵינָהּ יוֹרֶדֶת, אֲפִלּוּ לְאַחַר מִיתָה.

He must bury her with honor, with eulogy and lament as the custom of the place. And if her standing was higher than his, she is buried according to hers, "for a woman rises with her husband and never goes down, even after death."

And how he is to treat you, every day טו:יט

וְכֵן צִוּוּ חֲכָמִים שֶׁיִּהְיֶה אָדָם מְכַבֵּד אֶת אִשְׁתּוֹ יוֹתֵר מִגּוּפוֹ, וְאוֹהֲבָהּ כְּגוּפוֹ. וְאִם יֵשׁ לוֹ מָמוֹן, מַרְבֶּה בְּטוֹבָתָהּ כְּפִי מָמוֹנוֹ. וְלֹא יַטִּיל עָלֶיהָ אֵימָה יְתֵרָה, וְיִהְיֶה דִּבּוּרוֹ עִמָּהּ בְּנַחַת, וְלֹא יִהְיֶה עָצֵב וְלֹא רַגְזָן.

The Sages commanded that a man honor his wife more than himself, and love her as himself. If he has money, he spends it on her good. He must not cast fear over her. He speaks to her gently. He is not sad with her, and he is not angry.

And to hear her וְשִׂמַּח אֶת אִשְׁתּוֹ

The ketubah is a contract, so it lists what a court can measure. The responsibility for how she feels is written somewhere else: in the Torah itself, and in the Gemara.

Her happiness is his assignment דברים כד:ה · ספר החינוך מצוה תקפ״ב

נָקִי יִהְיֶה לְבֵיתוֹ שָׁנָה אֶחָת, וְשִׂמַּח אֶת אִשְׁתּוֹ אֲשֶׁר לָקָח.

He shall be free for his home for one year, and he shall make his wife happy. The Torah releases a new husband from the army and from every public duty for a whole year, and gives him one job in their place: her happiness. The Sefer HaChinuch counts this as a mitzvah in its own right. Her emotional state is not a favor he does when he has time. It is his responsibility, by Torah law, from the first day.

Her tears are close בבא מציעא נט.

אָמַר רַב: לְעוֹלָם יְהֵא אָדָם זָהִיר בְּאוֹנָאַת אִשְׁתּוֹ, שֶׁמִּתּוֹךְ שֶׁדִּמְעָתָהּ מְצוּיָה, אוֹנָאָתָהּ קְרוֹבָה.

Rav said: a man must always be careful never to wound his wife with words, because her tears are close at hand, and so her hurt is close at hand. The Gemara is not telling her to toughen up. It is telling him that she feels more, and faster, than he does, and that knowing this, and being careful with her, is his job. A man who hears her, who notices before the tears, is doing what Rav asked.

Now open your eyes.

הֲרֵי אַתְּ מְקֻדֶּשֶׁת לִי

"You are mine" means "you are my responsibility" before it means anything else.
How do you feel?

Rav Yisrael Frenkel · The Love You're Meant to Build · yisraelfrenkel.com · Sources: the standard Ashkenazi ketubah; Rambam, Mishneh Torah, Hilchot Ishut 12–15; Devarim 24:5 with Sefer HaChinuch 582; Bava Metzia 59a